



**WHEN YOU'VE** written many of these columns, it's not rare to find yourself stuck for ideas, or struggling with writer's block. It's been well over 100 for me, and this month I was in a real dry patch for ideas. Because we were covering PCs in so many places, I knew I wanted to write a non-PC column... but what?

As is usually the case, a casual Team Digit chat resulted in Siddharth mentioning something about meritocracy, and I brought up a story (Fran-chise) by my favourite author Isaac Asimov, and then one thing led to another and 9 minutes later a column was born.

The idea is simple, really. Humans are prone to biases, and most of the time, they aren't even aware of their biases. It's not just racial bias, but gender biases, age biases and even educational qualification biases. It's not uncommon for a recruiter from a top college to want to recruit others from top colleges, and in the field of coding, someone invented the term "brogrammer" to describe this bias.

How do you get rid of bias? Why AI of course! If humans have biases (known or unknown to themselves), surely AI will do away with them? If a meritocracy is ever to be achieved, surely a machine is the perfect HR head, because it will look only at skills and qualifications and parameters we teach it, and will thus ignore other factors it's not programmed to compute with, such as gender, or race, etc., right?

In theory, this is arguably the only way to arrive at a meritocracy, and if done right, it can indeed work, but it will need actual artificial "intelligence", and not merely creative human programming. For now, I'd rather humans use their own brains and have the rudimentary AIs that we have now watch and analyse and create reports after the hiring is done.

And this isn't something I do flippantly, because this topic hits closer to home for me than anyone else in Team Digit. I'm by far the least qualified of all of the members of Team Digit who have ever worked here. An engineering dropout (twice!), I'm still an under-grad, and I wouldn't make it into any company, or even an interview, if all they had to go on was the CV of a 20-something me.

I should be doing cartwheels of joy that so many others like me will not be ruled out because

they are missing a piece of paper that HR execs deem vital, but I'm not. This is because the AIs will be given parameters to find "successes" and will be given patterns to study. Certain types of people will be deemed to be better at, say, web development, and those stereotypes will continue. Machines just aren't quirky enough to spark an interest the way a human would.

For example, if you read this article, and happen to get a CV from an undergraduate who dares apply for a position that you have specified a bachelor's degree for... perhaps some of you might be swayed just enough to call her in for an interview. Essentially, it's the human condition that gives people like me a shot at a job, for better or worse. A machine would just never do that, because statistically, I'd be a bad bet.

Then there's the question of eugenics (of sorts) where relying only on one machine's ideas of good employees might end up ruining a company by reducing diversity, instead of increasing it. Then again, a machine that was programmed to maintain or increase diversity might give unfair preference to minorities... The complications are endless...

I mentioned Asimov's short story called *Fran-chise* (read it if you can), and that was because what works for job hiring today, might work for immigration tomorrow, or elections day after, and pretty soon we find that machines are indirectly running our world by electing our officials, CEOs, politicians and bosses.

Thankfully, there are other people like me, with the same fears as mine, who are also working on this. Tara (*Talent Acquisition and Recruiting Automation*) is an example of an attempt to get AI to create a true meritocracy by ignoring paper qualifications and focussing on competency.

Unilever is using AI to hire for entry-level jobs, and it gets candidates to play neuroscience-based games against the AI, and this helps it screen out applicants that are incompatible with the company's requirements.

With thousands of applicants for every job in a big company, there's no choice but to use AI to whittle down the numbers, but I hope the skills of the people training the AI itself are up to the mark...



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